Josephine Auer

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Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) Cambridge, MA
PhD in Economics, expected 2031
Current cumulative graduate GPA: 5.0/5.0
Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellow

University of Oxford Oxford, UK
MPhil in Economics, 2023–2025
Distinction
Rhodes Scholar (Queensland and Magdalen College), University of Oxford

The University of Queensland Brisbane, Australia
Bachelor of Mathematics, 2022 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)
Bachelor of Advanced Finance and Economics (Honours Class I), 2019 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)
Vice Chancellor's Scholar

Graduate Coursework

Research fields: Micro Theory, Behavioural Economics, Industrial Organisation, Organisational Economics
MIT Fall 2025 (completed):
14.164 Foundations of Behavioural Economics (A), 14.281 Contract Economics (A), ECON2059 Decision Theory (A), 14.271 Industrial Organisation I (listener)

MIT Spring 2026 (completed):
14.163 Algorithms and Behavioural Science, 14.283 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics I, 14.284 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics II, 14.126 Game Theory (listener), 14.273 Advanced Topics in Industrial Organisation (listener)

MIT Fall 2026 (in progress):
15.838 Research Seminar in Marketing, 14.192 Advanced Research & Communication, 14.282 Organisational Economics, 14.472 Public Economics II (listener)

Research Papers

Under review

- *When Does Static Willingness to Pay Mislead? A Framework for Dynamic Hedonic Valuation*
- *A Secret Worth Keeping? Bid Cap Design in Budget-Constrained Procurement Auctions* (with Lana Friesen and Ian A. MacKenzie)

Research in Progress

- *How Far Can Firms Push Product Claims? Demand, Attention, and Strategic Representation*: a structural model of firms' product claims and rationally inattentive consumer demand, studying when attention and competition discipline exaggeration.

- *Optimal Bandwagons: Consensus Building with Public Pressure*: a model of evidence access and voting order showing when public pressure helps secure unanimous approval and when an approval-seeking sponsor benefits from protecting independent scrutiny.
- *AI Assistance and Misperceived Learning*: an experiment testing whether AI assistance distorts beliefs about human capital accumulation by inducing overprediction of later unaided performance (with Eric Gao).
- *Commitment Cascades*: a model of delayed commitment demand in which naive present-biased agents update from failed intentions, generating cross-environment cascades in sophistication and take-up (with Eric Gao).
- *AI and Skill Development in Frontline Health Work*: a planned experiment testing how AI advice and feedback during training affect community health workers' later unaided counselling skills and transfer to unfamiliar cases (with Madhavi Jha and Lauren Rice).
- *Diagnosing Behavioural Hazard in the Age of Algorithms*: a planned field experiment testing whether AI support tailored to patients' barriers improves diabetic retinopathy follow-up beyond standard information and reminders (with Zachary Wojtowicz).
- *Modern Slavery*: a decision-theoretic model of risky migration and trafficking vulnerability under uncertainty (with Ian Jewitt).

Selected Policy Research Outputs

- Auer, J. (2022), *Disengaged: The costs and possible causes of youth disengagement in Australia*, e61 Research Note Series.
- Andrews, D., Auer, J., Elias, M., La Cava, G., and Mercier, L. (2022), *The effect of the COVID-19 recession on the youth labour market in Australia*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Clarke, E., Hayward, Z., La Cava, G., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Preventing scarring in the post-pandemic youth labour market*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Dwyer, E., Hayward, Z., Kaplan, G., La Cava, G., Michielsen, A., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Better harnessing Australia's talent: five facts for the Summit*, e61 Institute.

Research Experience

University of Oxford, Economics of Modern Slavery Initiative 2024–present
Research Contributor

e61 Institute 2022–2023
Predoctoral Analyst

The University of Queensland, School of Economics 2019–2022
Economics Research Assistant

Selected Honours and Awards

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellowship, MIT, 2025–present
Rhodes Scholarship (Queensland), Oxford, 2023
University Medal, UQ, 2020
UQ Graduate of the Year, UQ, 2020
Valedictorian, UQ School of Economics, 2019
Vice Chancellor's Scholarship, UQ, 2016–2022